Code

The Hidden Language of Computer Hardware and Software

By Charles Petzold

First Published: 1999 | Category: Technology & Programming | ISBN: 9780735611313
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Canonical URL: https://openlibrary.org/works/OL1963918W

SYNOPSIS & EDITORIAL NOTE

Beginning with flashlights, Morse code, and Braille, Charles Petzold builds a complete working computer from first principles.

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CHAPTER 1 (EXCERPT)

Best Friends

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You're 10 years old. Your best friend lives across the street. In fact, the windows of your bedrooms actually face each other. Every night, after your parents have declared bedtime at the usual indecently early hour, you still need to exchange thoughts of critical importance.

If your bedroom windows are within sight of each other, you can use flashlights. Turning the flashlight on and off in patterns of short and long flashes -- dots and dashes -- allows two ordinary household circuits of battery, wire, and bulb to transmit human language across space without a sound.